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Linux cryptoworm

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F1 - step forward

With a slew of rule changes being introduced in the current season of Formula 1, here's a peek at some of the new changes



0-Whoa! in 2 seconds flat

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As a new F1 season rolls around, fans all over the world have fastened their seatbelts to get in on the racing action. The season testing in Jerez (Spain) and the premiere Grand Prix in Melbourne only reaffirmed the fact that Formula One can still be a highly competitive sport and not just a boring merry-go-round of sorts. Further, the rule changes has had some massive effects on the fortunes of the competing teams.

This year's rule changes focus on safety, fuel saving and energy recovery. Dubbed by pundits as one of the "biggest reconditioning exercises in the history of the sport", the new changes affect the engine, fuel limit and aerodynamics.

Here's a look at the major changes impacting the sport that is considered to be the foremost form of car racing.

Fuel Saving

While F1 isn't exactly Captain Planet's favourite sport, the new fuel limit might

help assuage the green guardian. This year, the fuel limit has been slashed down by a brutal 30 per cent, which means almost 50 kgs less than the usual capacity. While teams could previously guzzle unlimited fuel, they usually used about 150 kgs per race. The new limit means that drivers will be working on different schemes to sustain the same amount of fuel for the entire length of the race, especially in the earlier laps.

Gear up for this

Well, quite literally, the number of gears in the cars have been upped from seven (in 2013) to eight this year. While in the previous season, teams could pick and choose seven from a total of 32 ratios, the ratios have now been slashed down to a not-so-grand total of eight. Until last year, teams could tailor the gearbox to meet the requirements for each track. This year, teams will be allowed to change their ratios only once. What this means is that if a team has had the misfortune of picking the wrong set of ratios, they could potentially doom their chances of ever making it across the finish line. And to answer the

question about why the additional gear was allocated: one could speculate that with low capacity engines, drivers would be prompted to push the cars harder. The additional gear would result in smoother delivery of power across the rev band.

The engine revolution

After a bit of a tug of war, teams have finally bid goodbye to the mighty 2.6-litre V8 engine and have accepted the leaner 1.6-litre V6. While the V8 was naturally aspirated – meaning: all the power was derived from combustion taking place in the cylinders without the use of any fancy bells and whistles – the V6 has a turbo-charger bolted on to it compensating for the power that was lost when the two cylinders and a litre of capacity were taken away.

The free revving capabilities of the V8 were also lost with the cylinders as the new engine hits the rev limiter at 15,000 RPM as opposed to 18,000 RPM in the previous season.

The lower rev limit helps produce lesser exhaust gasses as more fuel is required for a higher rev. Besides saving fuel (and the environment), the cap also reduces wear and tear on the engine. And considering that this year the number of engines have been restricted from eight to five, it seems like a pretty good idea.



1.6 Litre V6. Furore or furball?